

Module 1: Systems — Everything Is Connected (Whether You Like It or Not)

Learning Objectives

1. Identify the **systems** you're part of every day — friend groups, families, schools — and see how the parts depend on each other.
2. Understand what a **boundary** is and why knowing what's "inside" and "outside" a system helps you navigate life better.
3. Recognize how a change in one part of a system can create **ripple effects** through the whole thing.

Introduction

Imagine your friend group as a group chat. When one person starts drama, does it stay between just two people? Almost never. It ripples out. Other friends take sides, someone screenshots the conversation, suddenly lunch is awkward for everyone. That's because your friend group isn't just a bunch of individual people — it's a **system**.

A system is any collection of parts that are connected and affect each other. Your school is a system. Your family is a system. Even your morning routine is a system — if your alarm doesn't go off, you skip breakfast, which means you're hungry in first period, which means you can't focus, which means you bomb the quiz. One small change, big consequences.

Understanding systems is like getting X-ray vision for how the world actually works. Let's turn it on.

Key Concepts

1. What Makes Something a System?

A **system** has three things: **parts**, **connections between those parts**, and a **purpose** (something the whole thing does that the parts can't do alone).

Think about a basketball team. Five players on the court are just five people. But when they know the plays, communicate, and work together, they become something more — a team that can win games. The "team" is the system. No single player IS the team.

Your school works the same way. Teachers, students, administrators, janitors, lunch staff — remove any one group and the whole thing breaks down. A school with no students is just an empty building. A school with no teachers is just daycare.

2. Boundaries: What's In, What's Out

Every system has a **boundary** — a line between what's part of the system and what's outside it. This is a bigger deal than it sounds.

Think about your family. There's a clear boundary: the people who live in your house, share meals, and have the Wi-Fi password. People outside that boundary — neighbors, teachers, friends — interact with your family system but aren't part of it in the same way.

Here's where it gets interesting: boundaries can be fuzzy. Is your best friend who eats dinner at your house three times a week part of your family system? Kind of? Boundaries aren't always walls — sometimes they're more like cell membranes, letting some things in and keeping other things out.

3. Ripple Effects: When One Thing Changes Everything

In a system, you can't change just one thing. Pull one thread and the whole fabric shifts.

Say your school decides to start 30 minutes later. Sounds simple, right? But now bus schedules change, after-school sports end later, parents adjust work schedules, homework time shifts, and suddenly kids are staying up later because they know they can sleep in. One change rippled through the entire system.

This is why understanding systems matters: it helps you predict consequences. Before you post that thing on social media, before you skip that assignment, before you say that thing to your friend — ask yourself, "What system is this part of, and what might ripple?"

Try It!

Map Your Morning System. Grab a piece of paper and list everything that has to happen between your alarm going off and you arriving at school. Draw arrows showing what depends on what. Now pick one thing and imagine it doesn't happen (your phone dies overnight, there's no milk for cereal, your sibling hogs the bathroom). Trace the ripple effects through your map. How many things change?

Summary

A **system** is a set of connected parts that work together. Your friend groups, family, school, and daily routines are all systems. Every system has a **boundary** separating inside from outside, and changes in one part create **ripple effects** throughout the whole system. Once you start seeing systems, you can't stop — and that awareness helps you understand why things happen and predict what might happen next. In the next module, we'll zoom in on the most important part of any system you're in: **you** — the agent.